

Chapter 10

The Same Fragrance

Roman took his seat across the table.

Elara kept her eyes on the documents in front of her.

Her father began the meeting.

"Thank you for coming. We appreciate Veyron's interest in the project."

Roman nodded.

"Thank you for having us."

His voice.

Elara's heart skipped.

She slowly looked up.

Their eyes met.

For one brief moment, everything else disappeared.

She saw the boy she had known.

Then the man sitting in front of her.

He looked different.

More confident.

More controlled.

But those eyes...

They were the same.

Elara quickly looked away.

Her heart was beating too fast.

She tried to listen to the discussion.

Investment figures.

Development plans.

Expected returns.

Elara pressed her right hand lightly against the other.

Think.

"Elara, your opinion?"

She looked up.

"About the revised timeline?"

"Yes."

She glanced through the documents.

"The commercial section may take longer to reach full occupancy."

Roman looked at her.

"Why?"

She looked back at him.

"Because the surrounding area is still developing. The projections are strong, but the demand may take longer to build."

Roman studied the figures.

Then nodded.

"I agree."

Elara blinked.

"You do?"

A faint smile touched his face.

"I wouldn't invest without considering the same risk."

She said nothing.

The meeting continued.

The discussion eventually moved toward the final terms.

Roman remained calm throughout.

He answered every question without hesitation.

There was no trace of the boy Elara remembered in the way he handled the meeting.

He seemed more certain now.

More experienced.

More difficult to read.

Her father looked impressed.

"Veyron has changed considerably in a short time."

Roman gave a slight smile.

"Sometimes change is necessary."

Elara looked at him.

The words stayed with her.

When the meeting finally ended, everyone began gathering their papers.

Her father stood and shook Roman's hand.

"Good meeting."

"Agreed."

Roman turned toward Elara.

For a moment...
neither of them spoke.
Then he extended his hand.
"Good to see you, Elara."
Her heart skipped again.
He had said her name so naturally.
She slowly placed her hand in his.
"Good to see you too."
His grip lasted only a moment.
Then he let go.
Roman turned and walked toward the door with his team.
Elara watched him leave.
The fragrance remained in the room.
Roman.
But one question still remained.
Why had he been there?
And why had he told her...
not to come?
Elara slowly stepped out of the conference room.
The hallway felt strangely quiet after the meeting.
She walked a few steps before stopping near the window.
Her mind was still stuck on the same thing.
Roman.
She looked toward the elevator.
Roman and his team were already walking away.
For a second, she almost called his name.
But she stopped herself.
What would she even say?
Why did you disappear?
Why were you at the library?
Why did you tell me not to come?
There were too many questions.
And no answers.
Elara looked down at her hands.

Her fingers still remembered the brief touch of his hand during the meeting.

She immediately pushed the thought away.

"This is ridiculous."

She took a slow breath and returned to her office.

The moment she sat down, her phone vibrated.

A message from Emma.

Do you need the documents for tomorrow's meeting?

Elara stared at the screen for a moment before replying.

Yes. Send them to me.

She placed the phone on the desk.

Then her eyes moved toward the window again.

Somewhere in the building...

Roman was still there.

She looked down at her phone again.

Her eyes moved to the unknown number.

The last message was still there.

You will know soon.

Elara stared at it.

A strange feeling settled in her chest.

She finally knew.

The fragrance had confirmed everything.

She opened the conversation.

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard.

For several seconds...

she didn't type anything.

Then finally:

I know it was you.

She read the sentence.

Her heart beat faster.

She almost deleted it.

But she didn't.

She pressed send.

The message appeared on the screen.

Sent.

Elara placed the phone on her desk.
She didn't know what she expected.
An explanation.
An apology.
Maybe nothing at all.
A few seconds passed.
Her phone vibrated.
Her eyes immediately moved toward the screen.
A reply.
Then you already know the answer to your question.
Elara frowned.
She read it again.
Her irritation returned.
"Seriously?"
She typed quickly.
No. I know you were there. I still don't know why.
She sent it before she could change her mind.
This time...
there was no immediate reply.
Elara leaned back in her chair.
For the first time since the library...
she wasn't questioning whether it had been Roman.
She was questioning why Roman had been there at all.

Across the building...
Roman stepped into a quiet hallway.
His phone vibrated.
He looked down.
Her message was still on the screen.
No. I know you were there. I still don't know why.
Roman read it slowly.
A faint smile appeared on his face.
Not amusement.
Something quieter.

He slipped the phone back into his pocket.

He had known she would ask.

The question was never whether she would.

It was when.

One of his team members called from farther down the hallway.

"Roman, we're ready."

He looked up.

"I'm coming."

He took one last glance toward the corridor leading back to Northbridge's conference rooms.

Then he walked away.

Some answers...

were better given face to face.

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By the time the office finally emptied, the sky outside had already turned dark.

Elara closed her laptop and gathered the files from her desk.

The entire day felt strangely long.

Not because of the meeting.

Because of him.

Roman.

She left the office without looking back.

When Elara finally reached home, the house was quiet.

She went upstairs, changed into comfortable clothes and sat on her bed.

For the first time all day...

she wanted silence.

She picked up a book from her bedside table and started reading.

For a while, the story distracted her.

Then...

her phone vibrated.

Elara glanced at the screen.

Unknown Number

She frowned.

She opened the message.

Only three words appeared.

Still hate me?

Elara froze.

She read it again.

Her fingers tightened around the phone.

Roman.

She stared at the number for several seconds.

Then she opened the contact options.

Her thumb hovered above the screen.

Slowly...

she typed a name.

Roman Ashford

She stared at it.

She pressed **Save**.

The name appeared beneath the number.

Roman Ashford.

Elara looked at it quietly.

Then she locked her phone.

But something inside her refused to settle.

She picked it up again.

Opened the message.

Still hate me?

Her eyes stayed on those words.

Then another thought crossed her mind.

She opened her notes and began typing.

You said he was dead.

She stopped.

Deleted it.

She tried again.

You told me Roman was dead...

Delete.

Her fingers moved again.

Then how is he standing in front of me?

She stared at the sentence.

Her breathing slowly changed.

Roman wasn't dead.

He hadn't disappeared from the world.

He had built an entire company.

He had become successful.

Powerful.

Respected.

And somehow...

he had been there in the library that night.

Elara put the phone down.

Her eyes filled with confusion.

For years, she had carried the same hatred.

She had believed she knew what Roman had done.

She had believed he was gone.

But now...

she didn't know what was true anymore.

She picked up the phone one last time.

This time, she didn't type a message.

She whispered to herself,

"I've hated him for three years..."

She looked at Roman's name on the screen.

"...but I never tried to know the truth."

A long silence followed.

Then she slowly shook her head.

"No."

Her voice was quieter now.

"I'm not going to hate someone because of what I was told."

She locked the phone.

"If Roman really did something..."

"I'll find out myself."

She placed the phone beside her.

For the first time...

Elara wasn't choosing Roman.

She wasn't forgiving him.

She wasn't trusting him.

She was simply choosing the truth.

And perhaps...

that was the first real step toward uncovering what had happened three years ago.